

Subject: How to Choose the Best Colors for Your Miniatures

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Hey Mini Painter,

Have you ever wondered why squigs from Warhammer are red? After all, they could be green, yellow or whatever color you can think of.

There is a very specific reason why the creators of Warhammer used red as the main color for squigs - it's the complementary color to the green goblins and orcs.

But how do you know which colors will look good together every time?

Today you will learn exactly that - you'll learn basics of color theory, how color harmonies work and how to pick the right colors to make your models pop!

The most important rule of color theory

If it looks good in black and white, most likely it'll look good in color. This touches on the same principle everyone talks about - contrast in values (or brightness).



Captain America from Marvel Crisis Protocol

In the above picture you can clearly tell which parts are exposed and which are in shade. You can even tell which surfaces are reflective (the shield) and which aren't.

As long as your painting follows this rule, rest assured that it won't look "wrong". However, there is always room to make it better.

Quick and easy solution

If you want to keep things very simple, you can do what professional designers do; pick 2 main colors and use them in 70/30 ratio.

When using this approach, keep in mind 2 additional things

- Use colors that are not too close on the color wheel
- Use neutral colors to fill in the less important parts

You might remember that I applied all of this on this Elementalist model.



Elementalist

For this mini, I used orange and purple (70% orange, 30% purple). On top of that, I filled in the rest with neutral colors (greys, browns and muted colors).

The 70/30 ratio makes the miniature well-balanced and the limited color palette creates harmonious look. However, we can take it a step further with **color harmonies**.

Color Harmonies For Miniature Painting

For more complex color choices, you should use a color wheel. In most of my paintings I use either triadic or complementary color harmonies.

Complementary colors



Color wheel is from Adobe Color

Most people are familiar with this color harmony. In the above example, the color choice is almost exactly the same as for "Hammers of Sigmar" Stormcast Eternals.

Another notable example is the pairing of red squigs and green goblins.

This harmony is used to portray the striking difference between colors, since you are using the opposite sides of the color wheel.

This doesn't mean that those are the only colors on the mini, however. It's acceptable to use other colors (especially neutral colors) to fill in the minor details.

In some cases, I don't restrict myself to a particular color scheme, but **use complementary colors in a way, that makes some features stand out more.**



Rocket Executive Perion

Here I use greens, oranges, yellow, red and neutral colors. Notice,

how the red jacket stands out against the green environment (wall was purposely tinted with green too).

The usage of complementary colors (along with usage of brighter colors) keeps the focus on the top of the model.

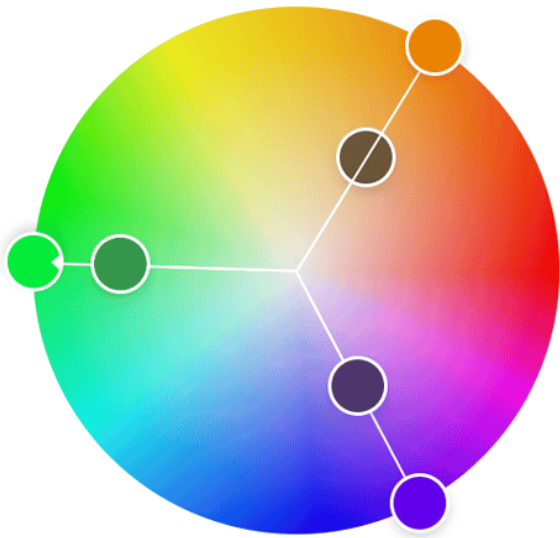
Another variant of the complementary scheme is **split complementary**, which just extends the possible range of one of the colors - for example, green + red and orange.

You can always play around with these schemes at [Adobe Color](#).

Triadic color harmony

This harmony uses 3 colors that are about evenly spaced on the color wheel.

Usually we recognize either primary triad (red, blue and yellow) or secondary triad (green, purple and orange).



You might also recognize the same color scheme from my Incubi unit.

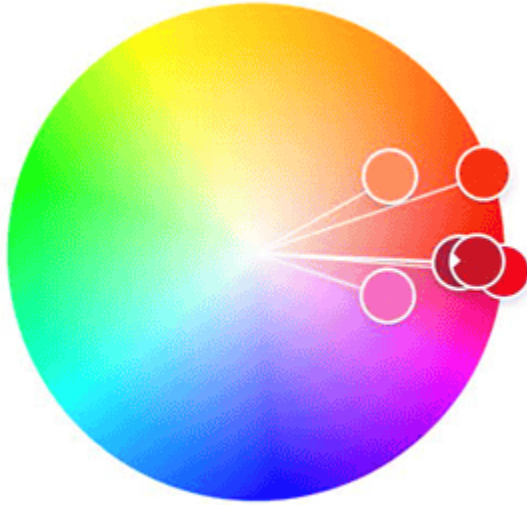
The great thing about color schemes is that the base can be used for any color you are missing.

In the above example, without the base, the purple is visible just in the shadows of the skin. By adding purple on the base, we complete the color triad.

We can do the same thing for the Elementalist (scroll up) - by adding a green base, we complete the secondary triad as well!

Analogous and monochromatic

Analogous color scheme consists of colors that are close to each other on the color wheel. Monochromatic uses a single color in various lightness.



Scarlet Witch represents an analogous color scheme. Most colors are in the red family, with some spread into pink and orange for the skin.

Both of these color schemes are used to portray harmony without too much contrast. This can be very useful for calm and unified paintings.

Since you can't create much contrast with color in this case, the most important rule (contrast in value) applies here twice as much.

Again, you can use this in your own way - for example, use an analogous or monochromatic scheme, then break it in one spot to make that detail pop.

Very often you'll see a hybrid approach, rather than a strict following of any given color scheme.

All of the above principles can be used to a great extent on any miniature and can be summed up in the following facts:

- Brightness (value) is the most important feature of color
- Use very different colors (far from each other on color wheel) for contrast
- Use similar colors (close on color wheel) to create harmony
- Using many colors creates interesting result, but can be chaotic
- Using limited palette creates harmony, but can be boring
- Use neutral colors for less important features (browns, creams, greys...)

So you can either choose to pick a color scheme, fill the rest with

neutral colors and roll with it...OR you can apply the underlying principles and work with them.

Either way, understanding the "why" behind colors will always lead to better results.

Keep painting.

Zumikito

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